Demonstrator Graham Whitty at a 2012 meeting of the Gorey Chapter in Robert O'Connor's studio

first Challenge was to fit as many boxes as possible – Russian doll-style – within a given size. Challenges since then have included the lightest plate of apples – the size was fixed – a breakfast tray, a spinning wheel, a model traction engine and, most recently, a bicycle, as featured in last month's issue of *Woodturning* magazine.

The IWG's structure

The National Executive Committee members are elected annually at the AGM with the exception of the President who serves a four-year fixed term of office. Office bearers may serve a maximum of five years. This is meant to revitalise the National Executive Committee but in reality it can be difficult to get volunteers to serve on the Committee and officers often remain on the Committee albeit in a different role.

Since 1983 the Seminar has been an item on the agenda for every National Executive Committee meeting and not just the upcoming Seminar but also looking ahead to future events.

One problem that has tested the National Executive Committee over recent years is the thorny issue of insurance. The insurance for all the activities of the Guild including Chapters is arranged centrally and as woodturning has developed over the years it has become increasingly important to get the correct cover for the activities of the Guild.

The National Executive Committee spends quite a lot of time discussing how the Chapters are meeting the aims of the IWG in what they offer their members. As mentioned above, the quarterly Chapter reports in *The Journal* give a good outline of what is going on around the country but there are, and always will be, variations in what Chapters are able to offer to their membership, especially those who meet on mid-week evenings. The National Executive Committee tries to support all Chapters through grants towards the purchase of new equipment, towards bringing demonstrators from outside the immediate area and towards running local one-day seminars.

Membership of the IWG has fluctuated over the years, from a low of about 700 to more than 800. Having seen falling numbers for the past few years, however, the figures are beginning to climb again. It is the intention of the National Executive Committee to continue to promote the IWG and to increase membership as this is currently the only source of income. Encouraged by the Design and Craft Council of Ireland several members of the National Executive Committee have participated in a 'Business to Arts' programme and it is hoped that this will lead to sourcing other funding streams which will be used to set up training programmes for tutors, demonstrators and members. ●

Contacts: Eugene Grimley and Peter Lyons are the IWG's Vice-Chairman and Honorary Secretary respectively. Both are accomplished woodturners.
Web: www.irishwoodturnersguild.com

WT_288_38_41_IWG 25 yearsbdckmbIWGSD.indd 41 09/12/2015 13:04